

Qroo Spanish Crew

Lesson Summary / Reported Speech

1. Direct vs. Indirect Speech

Direct speech: a literal quote.

Indirect speech: a paraphrase of what was said.

Examples:

- Direct: María dijo: «Quiero ir a la playa.»
María said, "I want to go to the beach."
 - Indirect: María dijo que quería ir a la playa.
María said that she wanted to go to the beach.
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2. The Word “que” = “that” (when it fits)

In English, we can often drop “that,” but in Spanish you must include **que** whenever you could put “that” in English.

Examples:

- María dice que quiere ir a la playa.
María says (that) she wants to go to the beach.
- La casa que compré es verde.
The house (that) I bought is green.
- La pizza que comí anoche estaba deliciosa.
The pizza (that) I ate last night was delicious.

If you **cannot** naturally add “that” in English, then you don’t use **que** in Spanish.

3. Reporting Verb in the Present

If the reporting verb is in the present, there is no tense shift in the quote.

Examples:

- Direct: «Quiero ir a la playa.»
"I want to go to the beach."

- Indirect: María dice que quiere ir a la playa.
María says that she wants to go to the beach.
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4. Reporting Verb in the Past

When the reporting verb is past, tense shifts occur. Here are the main patterns:

a) Present → Imperfect

- Direct: Juan dijo: «Estoy cansado.»
Juan said, "I'm tired."
 - Indirect: Juan dijo que estaba cansado.
Juan said that he was tired.
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b) Future → Conditional

- Direct: María dijo: «Iré a la playa mañana.»
María said, "I will go to the beach tomorrow."
 - Indirect: María dijo que iría a la playa al día siguiente.
María said that she would go to the beach the next day.
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c) Preterite → Preterite / Past Perfect

- Direct: Juan dijo: «Visité a mis padres ayer.»
Juan said, "I visited my parents yesterday."
 - Indirect (option 1): Juan dijo que visitó a sus padres ayer.
Juan said that he visited his parents yesterday.
 - Indirect (option 2): Juan dijo que había visitado a sus padres ayer.
Juan said that he had visited his parents yesterday.
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d) Present Perfect → Past Perfect

- Direct: María dijo: «He terminado mi tarea.»
María said, "I have finished my homework."

- Indirect: María dijo que había terminado su tarea.
María said that she had finished her homework.
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e) Imperfect → Imperfect (no change)

- Direct: Juan dijo: «Cuando era niño, jugaba en el parque todos los días.»
Juan said, "When I was a child, I used to play in the park every day."
 - Indirect: Juan dijo que cuando era niño, jugaba en el parque todos los días.
Juan said that when he was a child, he used to play in the park every day.
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f) Past Perfect → Past Perfect (no change)

- Direct: María dijo: «Ya había estudiado el tema.»
María said, "I had already studied the topic."
 - Indirect: María dijo que ya había estudiado el tema.
María said that she had already studied the topic.
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g) Imperative → Imperfect Subjunctive

Commands in direct speech become imperfect subjunctive in indirect speech.

- Direct: Juan dijo: «Cierra la puerta.»
Juan said, "Close the door."
 - Indirect: Juan dijo que cerrara la puerta.
Juan said to close the door.
 - Direct: María me dijo: «No abras la ventana.»
María told me, "Don't open the window."
 - Indirect: María me dijo que no abriera la ventana.
María told me not to open the window.
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5. Exceptions: Keeping the Present

Even with a past reporting verb, sometimes the present tense is kept:

- If the statement is still true now.

- If repeating what was just said in conversation.

Examples:

- María dijo que vive en México.
María said that she lives in Mexico.
 - Él dijo: «Tengo hambre.» → Él dijo que tiene hambre.
He said, "I'm hungry." → He said that he is hungry.
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6. Reported Questions

a) With Question Words (keep accent marks)

- Direct: María preguntó: «¿Cuándo llegó Juan a casa?»
María asked, "When did Juan get home?"
 - Indirect: María preguntó cuándo llegó Juan a casa.
María asked when Juan got home.
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b) Yes/No Questions (use si, no accent)

- Direct: Juan preguntó: «¿Quieres venir a la fiesta?»
Juan asked, "Do you want to come to the party?"
- Indirect: Juan preguntó si quería ir a la fiesta.
Juan asked if I wanted to go to the party.

Reported Speech Tense Shifts

Category	Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
Present → Imperfect	"Estoy cansado."	Dijo que estaba cansado.
Future → Conditional	"Iré a la playa mañana."	Dijo que iría a la playa al día siguiente.
Preterite → Preterite or Past Perfect	"Visité a mis padres ayer."	Dijo que visitó a sus padres ayer. / Dijo que había visitado a sus padres ayer.
Present Perfect → Past Perfect	"He terminado mi tarea."	Dijo que había terminado su tarea.
Imperfect → Imperfect	"Cuando era niño, jugaba en el parque."	Dijo que cuando era niño, jugaba en el parque.
Past Perfect → Past Perfect	"Ya había estudiado el tema."	Dijo que ya había estudiado el tema.
Imperative → Imperfect Subjunctive	"Cierra la puerta."	Dijo que cerrara la puerta.
Imperative → Imperfect Subjunctive	"No abras la ventana."	Me dijo que no abriera la ventana.